

Ancient Rome

BEFORE 500 CE

From a small farming settlement in the 10th century BCE, ancient Rome grew to become one of the largest empires in history. At its peak, the Roman Empire was home to as many as 70 million people, covered much of Europe and North Africa, and extended well into Asia.

Early Rome was originally ruled by kings, but in 509 BCE the Romans overthrew the seventh king, Tarquin the Proud, and set up a republic. Rome was now run by a system of elected officials, led by two consuls who ruled alongside a council called the Senate. This council was initially made up only of patricians (wealthy landowners), but over time the

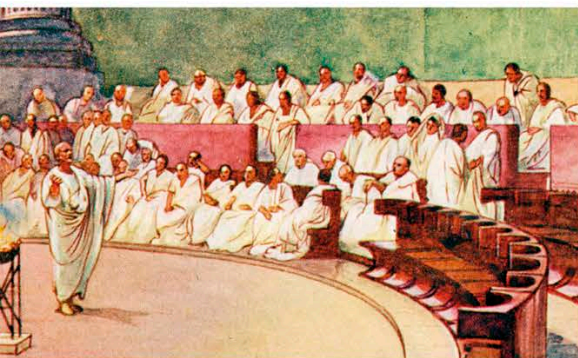
plebeians (poorer citizens) managed to win more political power.

Rome prospered and grew. It expanded south into Sicily and North Africa, and by the 2nd century BCE the Romans were in control of most of the Mediterranean. After around 100 BCE, civil war began to tear the Roman Republic apart. After a long power battle, Julius Caesar became dictator for life in 44 BCE, but was soon killed. His heir, Augustus, then defeated his rivals to become the first emperor of Rome in 27 BCE. The Roman Republic had become the Roman Empire, and once again power rested almost entirely with one person. It would remain this way, passing from emperor to emperor, for the next 500 years.



ROMULUS AND REMUS ▲

According to legend, Rome was founded by twin brothers Romulus and Remus, who were sons of the war god Mars. They were raised by a female wolf. Romulus killed his brother and became the first king, giving the city his name.



◀ ROMAN SENATE

Only men could join the Senate. Originally, its role was only to offer advice to the king, but during the Roman Republic it became much more powerful, making key decisions. The Senate's role diminished when Rome became an empire.



Helmet crests were made of feathers or horse hair.

THE ROMAN EMPIRE

27 BCE

Julius Caesar's heir Augustus defeats his rivals to become the first emperor of Rome.

69–79 CE

After a year of civil wars, Vespasian emerges victorious and restores some stability. He builds the huge Colosseum amphitheater in Rome, which still stands today.